

December 6, 1998

1998-2004 Tutor/Mentor Connection collaboration with
Steve Roussos, U Kansas PhD student in 1998
1998 correspondence-getting acquainted.

Dear Dan,

Hope all is well. Thanks for your recent email and your great ideas. I hope my letter will help advance those ideas and our work together. It's a bit long and I ask for your patience as I explore some ideas and developments with you.

My time away was productive and fun. Less than a week after I was with you in Chicago I went to D.C. for the Annual American Public Health Conference. There was an estimated 15,000+ members there from all over the world. I had a chance to do three presentations: the YouthFriends evaluation, some of our work and findings with teaching by distance education and the internet, and some evaluation work on how coalitions can influence childhood hunger in their communities. The feedback was very encouraging. As with your conference, this was a great way to meet people doing great work and find new partners. I've enclosed my presentation and speaking notes from the YouthFriends presentation and some copies of the overheads from the other presentations to give you a better idea of some the work.

After a week in D.C., I went to Maine for an extended Thanksgiving holiday with my fiancée Pam (she's attending medical school there). It was good to have some quiet time to reflect after the rush of energy and ideas of the two conferences. Too often the high and great ideas following conferences get lost after returning to work. I spent some time reviewing what I learned and designing a plan to do some of things we discussed and some ideas that have been percolating in my mind for some time but were energized by our time together. That's what I'll share with you here and ask for your feedback.

I'm not sure if I communicated this to you clearly while I was there, but I was beyond impressed with my experiences in Chicago. The conference was fantastic. I attend three to four conferences each year, some research oriented, some practice oriented, some both. I can't think of one I have been to that matched the richness in content (diversity and quality) and in active participation by both presenters and participants as your conference. The atmosphere was rich with trust and sharing. Granted I did not see all the presentations and was not able to stay until Saturday, but I bet what I saw were not the exception but the rule. Thanks for inviting me.

Though the conference was great, what I could not get out of my head all the way back to Kansas and even now, was your excitement, generosity, and commitment toward making a positive difference for the children of Chicago and those who work toward their benefit. This gave me great energy. I know many others share these qualities, but it's rare to see them shine as sincerely as they do through you. Also, stuck in my head were your ideas for setting up ways to impact youth throughout their development into young adults and your strategies to enhance volunteer organizations' abilities to do this. What you and your team do and represent incorporate the best of both worlds I work in.

First, while your work targets youth, as does YouthFriends, you do not represent the interests of any one organization but focus on helping all youth volunteerism groups to do better. This allows you to remain fairly neutral and build trust across organizations while avoiding the trap of being seen as a threat to other volunteer organizations who may

worry you are stealing resources from them. It is clear that you are seen as a support and valuable asset by other organizations. Conversely, while YouthFriends is expanding exponentially and is trying to be a vehicle to improving school-based volunteerism, it remains a specific type of volunteer initiative. One of the main roles of our university group has been to help YouthFriends avoid being a volunteer program and to develop an identity as a community-wide catalyst for helping school districts enhance and expand volunteerism for youth. However, YouthFriends' role and function is still largely seen as being for YouthFriends first and for other organizations only as they support YouthFriends mission and objectives. These are the types of trap I noticed your group avoids.

The second benefit I see in how your group works is your way of doing evaluation without being based in a university. While you attract university resources and support, you are not bound by the slow and too often self-serving academic structures. Don't get me wrong, I've benefited greatly from being at a university. Our group is paid to think, to gain greater understanding, and to help others through these endeavors. However, our ability to act quickly and be flexible to needs of our primary audience, community health initiatives and partnerships, is limited by formal and informal restrictions inherent in a university atmosphere. I was reminded of this during a session at the public health conference. The session was on how to make research, largely conducted by universities, understandable and applicable to the common citizen whose tax dollars pay for this research. A panel made up of top advisors in the National Institutes of Health and similar research funders discussed their efforts and challenges toward this end. Though they were hopeful, they showed no results or any evaluation of how they made research findings applicable to citizens and organizations.

I've been very fortunate to find a work group where understanding is balanced with a need to impact how communities can influence their health and social concerns. For the past three years I've been in an environment where I learn equally with my academic colleagues and the people in the organizations who see me as an "evaluator." In reality, the groups and communities we work with are my primary teachers and my research team is a teaching assistant that clarifies and develops lessons from the community. It's ironic, but one of the greatest compliments I receive is when those I serve say they forget that I'm "from the university" as I help them with their evaluation needs.

Our work with YouthFriends since 1996 is probably one of the best examples of a partnership between a university and a community group working for mutual gain and the common good. In some ways, our YouthFriends research team and the broader YouthFriends team (the central office and over 15 school districts, soon to jump to over 70) have been co-evolving - learning new ways to help each other succeed. But I have yet to sense the kind of commitment to understanding what works and striving to improve the capacity to improve the lives of youth as I did at your office. The main focus has been to get larger (get more school districts to join YouthFriends) not necessarily better. Though some individual school districts are looking for ways to get better (to see how to better improve youths' success or how to sustain volunteerism) while getting larger (more new volunteers) there is not much support for them. This is frustrating for me personally, especially when I am reminded that we are paid to serve the central office, not individual districts. Our contract with YouthFriends also prevents us from working with (or more

so, being trusted locally by) other youth volunteer organizations who might compete with YouthFriends. These things may change, and I think they will, but only if the leadership gains a greater curiosity to really know how to make a difference for youth. This is the type of curiosity I sensed while talking with you.

What I sensed at your office was more of a business-world attitude (I almost said "real-world"), a demand for research directly applicable to your work and development. You are willing to use university resources for such research. But more importantly, you conduct your own ongoing research to understand and improve your work and others' work. I have yet to see other nonprofit groups do that on their own initiative (though I noticed Amy Hyer moving in that direction). If you have examples of others I would love to know of them. (PS I only scanned through the two evaluation reports you had at your office. If possible and as your time permits, I'd love a copy of each. They would be very helpful for my dissertation work. I would also like to hear how you have used the information in those reports.)

Equally important was your concern and creative approach for outcomes, outcomes besides just getting larger, outcomes that demonstrate that Chicago is doing something to help youth go from kindergarten to the workplace. As I was listening to you describe a model of how this could happen. I remember thinking "wow, your vision is quite comprehensive and well thought out." And, for me, one of the most important outcomes I heard you emphasize was the "outcomes" of engaging others and enhancing their ability to do this work. There's too much to do and we cannot do it alone (even if we alone knew how); we must connect the strengths and resources of as many others as possible. Hearing you emphasize these points made me smile all over in agreement as I often thought you were reading my mind. These ideas reminded me of what was most important.

I am sure most of what I've said so far is familiar to you. I hope that what I have said will help you understand my ideas that follow. Dan, my discussions with you and actually seeing you practice what most only preach, have challenged me to also practice what I preach. I have decided to begin with two actions. First, I need to find some way to work with you more closely (assuming that will be acceptable to you too). I often preach to others to find the people who are doing the work they want to do and learn from them. As a matter of fact that's why I came to Kansas. I am confident you are someone I have much to learn from. So, as your time permits, I'd love to have a conversation of some possibilities for working with you more directly.

Second, I have decided to begin my own nonprofit organization for community research and development. I often preach to others to be creative, to find solutions to problems by doing things differently not as they've always been done. Well, now it's my turn to follow my own advice. I would like to create a team that provides research and development for the benefit of people and groups that are serious about improving the lives of youth on a community-wide level. As of now, I have few ideas on how I will do this and I'm sure it will take me some time. I think I have a name for it: Community Solutions Research and Development. I envision creating an organization that is not only interdisciplinary in the academic sense but also diverse in its sources of knowledge: businesses, policy makers, and civic leaders. The key distinction between this organization and others (as far as I have seen) is that we will highlight connecting research with the

development (improvement, discovery, etc.) of the groups with work with. We will not be working with groups to evaluate "thumbs up or thumbs down" whether they are effective or not, but rather we will be working with them to find out how to best apply evaluation to develop towards the successes important to them. I've been dreaming about what this organization might look like for the last year or so and I could use some brainstorming with you as to what it might look like and how it might function. I'm leaning towards making it a nonprofit organization, but I'm not sure I really know the pros and cons between having a nonprofit versus a for-profit. I will begin looking into how to begin this nonprofit when I return from the holidays in January. Any ideas or suggestions you might have would be greatly appreciated.

I will not be leaving Kansas until June 1999 after I complete my doctoral degree. Meanwhile, I'm focusing on finishing my review paper and dissertation, which is on the YouthFriends evaluation. I have begun searching for evaluation done by other volunteer organizations and summarizing their work and ways to connect with them. Come mid-January I will also have an intern to help me with this work. I will give you the link for this page as soon as we set it up, probably by February. I can also give you the information directly as I find it and you could add it to your site. Further, I would love to continue our discussions and include others around specific content areas (e.g., recruitment, volunteer development, marketing, etc.). We already have chat rooms in the YouthFriends evaluation page and in the Community Tool Box where we can hold discussions. However, I strongly suggest we use your site for such discussions because it is actually organized around such content areas and because it is not tied to any specific volunteer program. I will check out the Netbabbler you mention. I still need to check out the Group Systems product.

Between now and August, I'd like to find more specific ways to support you and I working together. You mentioned some options, among them beginning to write a book on how this type of work is done. By "work" I mean the work of community-wide development of volunteerism capacity for youth success from kindergarten to the workplace (though I'm sure that businesses and community institutions at large would also be improved by this work). I would be interested in discussing how I might help your organization develop its abilities to do what it is doing better while I enhance and learn new skills from working with you. A sample of questions or areas to explore might be:

How is TMC helping build and enhance the skills and resources of Chicago's volunteer efforts for youth? (Of course, we may apply all these questions beyond Chicago borders.)

How could TMC's ability to do this be improved?

How can TMC work better with other support organizations (e.g., foundations, and national volunteer organizations) to help Chicago volunteer organizations and programs?

How can we set up an ongoing evaluation system that would demonstrate how TMC is making a difference [in...]? (The maps are one excellent example!)

How can we set up an ongoing evaluation system that would help TMC and your partners make decisions that will lead to successful youth

development throughout the generations? (How does Chicago define success for youth?)

How can we create an ongoing evaluation system that shows the combined impact of Chicago volunteer organizations for youth success?

How can we best communicate TMC's and collaborators' past, current, and future work so as to enhance its dissemination to and application by others and generate resources for you and others doing this work?

I am not sure what the best way is to begin such work together. I am very interested in hearing to what degree you would find such work meaningful and other work you are interested in. I am confident we could generate some resources to allow us to work together more closely.

These are also the types of questions I would like to address with my own organization as it develops. I imagine that no matter where I end up after August I will still be connected with YouthFriends, my research colleagues, and you in some way. Ideally, we will be working together more directly.

Well, enough said for now. Thanks for listening. I look forward to your feedback and recommendations by phone, mail, or email. I can't thank you enough for the inspiration you've provided me. I hope I can do the same for you.

All the best for the holidays,

Χρόνια Πολλά!

Steve

→ "chrónia pōla"
(Greek for Happy Holidays)